The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Mother of the Planets

Āryagrahamātṛkā nāma dhāraṇī · Toh 997 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་གཟའ་ཡུམ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའ་གིན་ཟུང།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Mother of the Planets, known in Sanskrit as Āryagrahamātṛkā nāma dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phakpa Za Yum Zhejawé Zung, is a dhāraṇī scripture centered on the goddess revered as the Mother of the Planets. It opens in the great city of Aṭakāvatī, where the Buddha sits on a lion throne among bodhisattvas such as Vajrapāṇi. He is praised by a vast assembly of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and other beings, including the Sun, the Moon, the planets, Rāhu, Ketu, and the twenty-eight lunar mansions. The text concerns the protective power of this goddess's dhāraṇī to pacify the harmful influences of the planets and other celestial forces, making it a significant work for Buddhist practices connected with astrology and protection. It is Toh 997 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the dhāraṇī texts, the collection of incantations and protective formulas preserved in the Tibetan canon.

In the language of India: ārya grahamāhṛkā nāma dhāraṇī
In the language of Tibet: The Dhāraṇī Called the Noble Mother of the Planets.

Homage to the noble Blessed Lady, the Mother of the Planets.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was dwelling in the great city of Aṭakāvatī. He was praised by many beings: gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, mahoragas, māras, Yama, the Sun, the Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, Saturn, Rāhu, Ketu, the twenty-eight lunar mansions, and others. He was seated on a lion throne blessed with the ornament of the great vajra pledge. He was together with many bodhisattvas, namely the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, the bodhisattva great being Vajracaṇḍa, the bodhisattva great being Vajrasena, the bodhisattva great being Vajradhanu, the bodhisattva great being Vajrapati, the great bodhisattva Vajrālaṃkāra, the bodhisattva great being Vajraprabha, the bodhisattva great being noble Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva great being Samantadarśin, the bodhisattva great being Lokaśrī, the bodhisattva great being Padmaketu, the bodhisattva great being Blossoming Face, the bodhisattva great being Kṣitigarbha, the bodhisattva great being Padmanetra, the bodhisattva great being Mañjuśrī, and the bodhisattva great being Maitreya. Surrounded and attended by these and many hundreds of others in

the saṅgha of bodhisattvas, he was teaching the Dharma. He was teaching the Dharma called the Wish-Fulfilling Jewel, the Ornament of the Great Array, which is virtuous in the beginning, virtuous in the middle, and virtuous in the end, excellent in meaning, excellent in wording, unadulterated, wholly delightful, and wholly purified.

Then, through the blessing of the Buddha, Vajrapāṇi looked at that assembly and rose. Through the blessing of his own miraculous power he circumambulated the Blessed One many thousands of times, bowed to him, and sat before him. With a proud bearing, seated firmly in the cross-legged posture, he looked at the assembly, joined his palms in the vajra gesture at his heart, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, the planets are fierce and of fierce form, violent and of violent form. With wrathful and angry minds they afflict and harm sentient beings and steal their vitality. Some steal their wealth and possessions. Some steal their lives. Some make long-lived beings short-lived. Since they thus afflict sentient beings with harm, I pray the Blessed One to explain the Dharma discourse through which sentient beings will be protected."

The Blessed One said, "Vajrapāṇi, it is excellent, excellent, that you, moved by compassion for the benefit of sentient beings, ask the Tathāgata about this great and utterly secret matter. I shall explain it. Listen, grasp it well and thoroughly, and keep it in mind. For the planets, who are of fierce form, extremely wrathful, and terrifying, I shall explain excellent worship, offering water, and excellent recitation, more secret than the secret.

Worshipped with offerings, they are propitiated;
if harm is done, they cause harm.
The colors of all those planets,
the way in which they are pleased,
and for the gods and the asuras,
the kiṃnaras and the nāgas,
the yakṣas and the rākṣasas,
the pūtanas and human beings,
those fierce ones of great splendor,
the secret mantras and the offerings
that pacify their wrath,
I shall explain in due order."

Then from the heart of the Blessed One Śākyamuni himself there issued a blazing ray of light called the Play of Compassion, and it entered the crowns of the planets' heads. Then, in that very instant, the planets, headed by the Sun, rose and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, has bestowed a healing gift upon us. We pray the Blessed One to teach the Dharma discourse. Blessed One, we pray you to explain that by which we will gather and become helpers to the preachers of the Dharma: protection, thorough safeguarding, peace and well-being, service rites and the averting of punishment, the warding off of weapons, the neutralizing of poison, the destroying of poison, the sealing of boundaries, and the binding of the ground."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, declared the worship and the secret mantras of the planets:

In the directions, distinguished by their colors in due order, one should make a maṇḍala of fragrant substances and draw the petals of a lotus measuring twelve finger-widths. The center, also twelve finger-widths, should be made beautiful with four gates in due order. Upon the open lotus one should visualize the god Sun: his body is a mass of splendor, like blazing vermilion, with rays of light equal to a thousand suns.
oṃ maigholkāya svāhā

In the east is the Moon, white.
oṃ śitāṃśabe svāhā

In the southeast, the corner of fire, is Mars, red.
oṃ raktāṃgakumārāya svāhā

In the direction of Yama, the south, is Mercury, of the warrior caste, yellow in color.
oṃ budhāya svāhā

In the southwest, the quarter of Nairṛti, is Jupiter, reddish yellow.
oṃ braṃhaspahaye svāhā

In the western direction is Venus, white.
oṃ asurottamāya svāhā

In the northwest, the quarter of the wind, is Saturn, intensely black like collyrium.

oṃ kṛṣṇavarṇṇlaya svāhā

In the direction of Kubera, the north, is Rāhu, reddish black.
oṃ amṛtapriyāya svāhā

In the northeast, the corner of Īśāna, is Ketu, the color of a smoky cloud.
oṃ jyotiketabe svāhā

At the eastern gate is the Lord Buddha, at the southern gate Vajrapāṇi, at the western gate the Lord of the World (Avalokiteśvara), and at the northern gate Mañjuśrī.

Outside the maṇḍala, in the northeast, are all the planets. In the southeast corner are the houses of the zodiac and the lunar mansions. In the southwest are all the harmful forces. In the northwest is the Venerable Great Knowledge Queen (Mahāvidyā). Outside the gates of the maṇḍala, in the east is Dhṛtarāṣṭra, in the south Virūḍhaka, in the west Virūpākṣa, and in the north Kubera.

For the Sun, milk porridge; for the Moon, rice with curd; for Mars, a dish of peas and black lentils; for Mercury, butter cakes; for Jupiter, milk; for Venus, cakes; for Saturn, peas, black lentils and mung beans mixed together; for Rāhu, sesame soup; and for Ketu, sesame soup and a dish of molasses.

As the torma for the yakṣas: for Dhṛtarāṣṭra, rice with curd; for Virūḍhaka, curd and a dish of peas and black lentils; for Virūpākṣa, a dish of milk porridge; and for Kubera, curd and a dish of peas and black lentils, with molasses mixed with beer.

Flowers of the colors corresponding to each, in order, are offered. Incense of the colors corresponding to each, in order, is offered. Banners of the colors corresponding to each, in order, are offered. A lamp is offered to each one. Worship is to be performed for each in its proper order. Filling a conch cup with butter and honey and placing the five precious substances in it, one offers the welcoming water, and a silk cloth should also be tied over the face.

Vajrapāṇi, these planets are accomplished by reciting their heart mantras. Having made a maṇḍala of scented powder twelve finger-widths across, matching the colors of each in order, one should worship in its center. Having offered the welcoming water in a vessel of bronze, copper or the like, or of gold or silver, one should recite the mantra one hundred and eight times for each of them.

Vajrapāṇi, then, after that, one should recite seven times the mantra words of the dhāraṇī called Mother of the Planets. Then all the planets, beginning with the Sun, will give protection. It frees one from the graha of poverty. Those whose life has run out will become long-lived.

Furthermore, Vajrapāṇi, whatever monks, nuns, laymen or laywomen, or whatever other beings belonging to the births of sentient beings, hear it with their ears, they too will not meet an untimely death.

Furthermore, Vajrapāṇi, for the preacher of the Dharma who worships in the center of the maṇḍala of the planets and recites this every day, all the planets will themselves fulfill all his wishes in every way. They will also put an end to poverty in his family line.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, spoke the dhāraṇī called Mother of the Planets:

namo buddhāya namo vajradhārāya namo padmadharāya namo kumārāya namo grahāṇāṃ sarvāśaparipūrakānāṃ namo nakṣatrāṇāṃ namo dvādaśarāśīnāṃ tadyathā oṃ buddhe buddhe vajre vajre padme padme sara sara prasara prasara smara smara krīḍaya krāḍaya māraya māraya mārdhaya mārdhaya ghāṭaya ghāṭaya sarvapighnāṃ kuru kuru mama kāryāṃ chindha chindha sarvaduṣṭāṃ kṣāpaya kṣāpaya śānte śānte dānte dānte hāmaya dāmaya svāhā drutānadarśaya ātmanaṃ rakṣa rakṣa māṃ sarvasatrāṃśca sarvagrahanakṣatra vidhvaṃsanivarttaya bhagavati mahāmāye prasādaya sarvaduṣṭaṃ śodhaya sarvapāpaṃ caṇḍe caṇḍe turu turu caṇḍeni caṇḍeni muyu suyu mucu mucu vaha vaha ugre ugratame pūraya me manorathaṃ paripūraya sarvatathāgata adhiṣṭhite samaye svāhā oṃ svāhā hūṃ svāhā hrī svāhā dhruṃ svāhā dhriṃ svāhā padmadharāya svāhā ādityāya svāhā saumāya svāhā dhāraṇīsutāya svāhā baudhāya svāhā pṛhaspataye svāhā śukrāya svāhā kṛṣṇavarṇṇaya svāhā rāhabe svāhā ketabe svāhā buddhāya svāhā vajradharāya svāhā padmadharāya svāhā kumārāya svāhā sarvagrahebhyaḥ svāhā sarvanakṣatrebhyaḥ svāhā sarvadvādaśarāśinibhyaḥ svāhā sarva upadravebhyaḥ svāhā oṃ sarvavidye hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā

Vajrapāṇi, if one begins with these mantra words of the dhāraṇī called Mother of the Planets on the seventh day of the waxing moon in the last month of autumn, the month of the Pleiades, takes the poṣadha vows, worships and recites every day until the fourteenth, and then on the full moon recites it without interruption day and night, then for ninety-nine years no fear of death will arise for that person. No fear will arise of falling meteors, or of torment by

the planets and lunar mansions. He will remember his former births. He will be honored by all the planets. The planets will grant him whatever boon he desires.

Then those planets said to the Blessed One, "Excellent!" and vanished.

This completes the dhāraṇī called the Noble Mother of the Planets.

It was translated during the lifetimes of the bodhisattva kings and ministers. Later, the layman Drakpa Gyaltsen compared it with an Indian manuscript at the hermitage of glorious Sakya and made it thoroughly correct.

Translator's Notes

• The city □□□□□□□□□ is taken as Aṭakāvatī (Alakāvatī), the city of Kubera named in the Sanskrit Grahamātṛkā, since □□□□□□□□□ renders Aṭavaka. The bodhisattva name □□□□□□□□□□□□ could not be identified with confidence and is translated literally as "Blossoming Face." In the list of Dharma qualities, □□□□□□□□□□□ ("wholly delightful") stands where the usual formula has "wholly complete"; it is translated as written. In the maṇḍala, □□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□, Venus, the doubled syllable being a copyist's slip.
• The Tibetan for Venus is written "ba ba sangs," evidently a slip for "pa sangs" (Venus), which is how it is translated. The instruction to recite "one hundred and eight" times repeats the syllables for "and eight" in the Tibetan; it is rendered as one hundred and eight. The silk cloth "tied over the face" is literal; the text does not specify whose face or what object is meant. The "dish of molasses" at the end of the planetary food list may be a separate item rather than part of Ketu's offering; the Tibetan is ambiguous.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.